straining our relationship with the Sri Lankan government/ said Avinash. 'But there are no permanent enemies and friends in the grey world. By 1987, all the outfits demanding a separate Eelam had become the enemy and we faced humiliation by sending in the Indian Peace Keeping Forces (IPKF). We were drawn into the war and had to suffer huge casualties at the hands of the very organisation we had trained, forcing us to withdraw within two years. But 2006 was different ball game altogether. It was the conscious decision of the Indian government headed by the Congress party to finish the LTTE.'

The IPKF was launched during the tenure of the then R&AW chief A.K. Verma. He had expected the IPKF to weaken the LTTE so that later, with the help of the Sri Lankan army, provincial council elections in the Tamil dominated northern and eastern provinces could be held for long-term peace. The IPKF's first offensive started in October 19 8 7 in Jaffna when the operation to capture LTTE chief Prabhakaran went haywire due to a massive intelligence failure, resulting in heavy casualties.

Serving R&AW officer Pawan Arora believes that signing the peace accord with Sri Lanka and launching the IPKF was a political blunder. The time was not ripe for an IPKF kind of operation in Sri Lanka as the LTTE, just a year earlier, had been trained by India. 'It was like fighting your own recruits,' Arora said. 'Moreover, groups like the LTTE were pressure groups for the Indian government against Sri Lanka.'

A CIA report in November 1987, a month after the offensive, said:

Over the short term, Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi still hopes that he can sufficiently weaken the main Tamil insurgent group LTTE, to force them adhere to the peace accord. At the